STORMWATER

Written by

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Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise.
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FADE IN:

1 EXT. SUBURBAN STREET - DAY 1

Heavy rain. Gutters run like rivers. A storm drain at the kerb gulps brown water.

A small scruffy terrier, BISCUIT, splashes after a tennis ball. The ball bounces once, twice, and drops through the grate of the STORM DRAIN.

Biscuit squeezes through the gap after it and vanishes.

REFILWE (11), yellow raincoat, red gumboots, runs down the pavement holding an empty lead.

REFILWE
Biscuit! Biscuit, no!

She drops to her knees at the drain. From below, faint and echoing, a bark.

2 INT. MUNICIPAL DEPOT - OFFICE - DAY 2

A prefab office. Hard hats on hooks. A kettle and a map of the town's drains pinned to the wall.

MR. VAN DER MERWE (50s), orange overalls, big moustache, eats a sandwich at his desk. A phone rings. He answers with his mouth full.

MR. VAN DER MERWE
Depot.

REFILWE (V.O.)
(on the phone, crying)
My dog is in the drain on Acacia Street and he can't get out!

He puts down the sandwich.

3 EXT. SUBURBAN STREET - DAY 3

A municipal truck with an orange light pulls up. Mr. Van der Merwe climbs down with a crowbar and a torch. His young colleague, SIBUSISO (20s), follows with a coil of rope.

Refilwe points at the drain.

REFILWE
He went in there.

Mr. Van der Merwe levers up the heavy steel MANHOLE COVER beside the drain. It clanks onto the road.

He shines his torch down a ladder into the dark. Water roars somewhere below.

SIBUSISO
The pipe runs under three streets. He could be anywhere.

REFILWE
He follows the ball. He always follows the ball.

4 INT. STORMWATER TUNNEL - CONTINUOUS 4

A round concrete tunnel, knee-deep in rushing water. Torch beams bounce off the curved walls.

Mr. Van der Merwe and Sibusiso wade forward. Sibusiso's rope is tied around his waist.

SIBUSISO
Biscuit! Here, boy!

Only the water answers.

MR. VAN DER MERWE
(stopping)
Shh. Listen.

A bark. Ahead and to the left.

5 INT. STORMWATER TUNNEL - JUNCTION - CONTINUOUS 5

Two tunnels meet. On a narrow concrete ledge above the water, Biscuit stands shivering, the tennis ball in his mouth.

Mr. Van der Merwe reaches up. Biscuit backs away, growling around the ball.

MR. VAN DER MERWE
He won't come.

SIBUSISO
He won't leave the ball.

Sibusiso thinks. Then he pulls a second tennis ball from his overall pocket, a bit chewed.

MR. VAN DER MERWE
Why do you have a tennis ball?

SIBUSISO
Why don't you?

He holds it up and squeaks it. Biscuit drops the first ball and leaps straight into Sibusiso's arms.

6 EXT. SUBURBAN STREET - DAY 6

The rain has stopped. Neighbours stand under umbrellas around the open manhole.

Sibusiso climbs out of the hole with Biscuit inside his overalls, only the dog's head poking out. The neighbours clap.

Refilwe runs to them. Biscuit licks her face all over.

REFILWE
Thank you! Thank you!

Mr. Van der Merwe climbs out last, soaked to the chest. He holds up the first tennis ball, dripping.

MR. VAN DER MERWE
He'll want this too.

REFILWE
(laughing)
Keep it. You earned it.

He looks at the ball. He puts it in his pocket.

FADE OUT.